Trump Says He Is Ending Limits on Methane From Oil Drilling

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President Donald Trump said on Tuesday that his administration is ending a rule from former President Joe Biden that aimed to cut **methane emissions** from oil and gas drilling. He made the announcement at a campaign rally in Lubbock, Texas.

Methane is an invisible gas and the main part of natural gas. Scientists estimate it is responsible for about a third of planet-warming **greenhouse gas** emissions, and it is far more powerful than carbon dioxide at warming the atmosphere in the short term. Oil and gas operations are the largest industrial source of methane.

Trump said the change would save companies and consumers billions of dollars and unlock 210 million barrels of oil, equal to about 10 days of U.S. **petroleum** use. He said the Biden plan crushed small operators with costly **regulations**, and he put the savings at $45 billion. The move aims to encourage more drilling at home as Trump faces criticism over high fuel prices.

Environmental Protection Agency Administrator Lee Zeldin previewed the changes last month. He said they would end the agency's **Super Emitter Program**, which required companies to investigate and repair major methane releases, and set less restrictive standards for small wells. Zeldin has said the old rule would have cost $18 billion and held back the U.S. energy industry.

Environmental groups criticized the **rollback**. They said it will let companies keep releasing gas that could be captured and used as energy for millions of households. Fred Krupp, president of the Environmental Defense Fund, said it gives companies a free pass at the expense of American consumers. The Biden rule, announced in 2023, was the first to cover existing wells as well as new ones, and officials under Biden said it would prevent an estimated 58 million tons of **methane emissions** by 2038.

Word Treasure

methane emissions -- Methane gas released into the air, often from oil and gas operations.

greenhouse gas -- A gas that traps heat in the atmosphere and warms the planet.

petroleum -- Oil and fuels made from oil.

regulations -- Official rules that limit or control what companies may do.

Super Emitter Program -- A program that required companies to investigate and repair major methane releases.

rollback -- The undoing or weakening of an earlier rule.

Background you need

Methane is a gas that is the main part of natural gas, a fuel used for heating and cooking.

When methane escapes into the air, it traps heat and warms the planet, especially in the short term.

Oil and gas drilling brings fuel out of the ground, and some methane can leak during that work.

Rules can limit how much methane companies may release, and capturing the gas means it can be used as fuel instead of escaping into the air.

Break it down

LEAD: President Donald Trump announced he is ending a Biden-era rule that aimed to cut methane emissions from oil and gas drilling.

KEY EVENT: The rollback, announced at a campaign rally in Lubbock, Texas, and previewed by the Environmental Protection Agency.

+- WHO: President Donald Trump, former President Joe Biden, EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin, and Fred Krupp of the Environmental Defense Fund.

+- WHAT: Ending the methane rule, including the Super Emitter Program, and setting less restrictive standards for small wells.

+- WHEN: Announced on Tuesday, after the changes were previewed last month; the Biden rule was announced in 2023.

EVIDENCE: Trump put the savings at $45 billion and the oil unlocked at 210 million barrels, while Zeldin said the old rule would have cost $18 billion.

OPEN QUESTION: How much methane will be released, and how fuel prices and drilling will change, after the rule ends.

Why it matters

Methane warms the planet and natural gas can heat homes, so rules about drilling affect both the climate and what families pay for energy.

Test what you remember

1. Where did President Donald Trump announce the end of the methane rule?

- (A) At a drilling site
- (B) In the White House briefing room
- (C) At a campaign rally in Lubbock, Texas
- (D) At the Environmental Protection Agency

2. What is methane the main part of?

- (A) Plastic
- (B) Gasoline
- (C) Natural gas
- (D) Coal

3. How many barrels of oil did Trump say the change would unlock?

- (A) 210 million barrels
- (B) 45 million barrels
- (C) 18 million barrels
- (D) 58 million barrels

4. Which program did Lee Zeldin say would end?

- (A) The Clean Air Program
- (B) The Super Emitter Program
- (C) The Fuel Price Program
- (D) The Small Wells Program

5. Who is Fred Krupp, as described in the article?

- (A) President of the Environmental Defense Fund
- (B) An oil company executive
- (C) The EPA Administrator
- (D) A former president

6. What was the first of its kind about the Biden rule announced in 2023?

- (A) It covered existing wells as well as new ones
- (B) It covered only new wells
- (C) It set no standards for small wells
- (D) It banned all drilling

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. President Donald Trump: He says the change would save companies and consumers billions of dollars, unlock oil, and encourage more drilling at home.

2. EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin: He says the old rule would have cost $18 billion and held back the U.S. energy industry.

3. Environmental groups: They criticize the rollback, saying gas that could be captured and used as energy for millions of households will keep being released.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):